Let’s Make a Mini Crossword!

2026-05-08

Is this presentation for you?

You may be interested in this presentation if:

- You are already familiar with the concept of "American-style" crosswords.
- You want to create a crossword using the standards prescribed by major crossword publishers.
- You are looking for a quick how-to rather than theory.

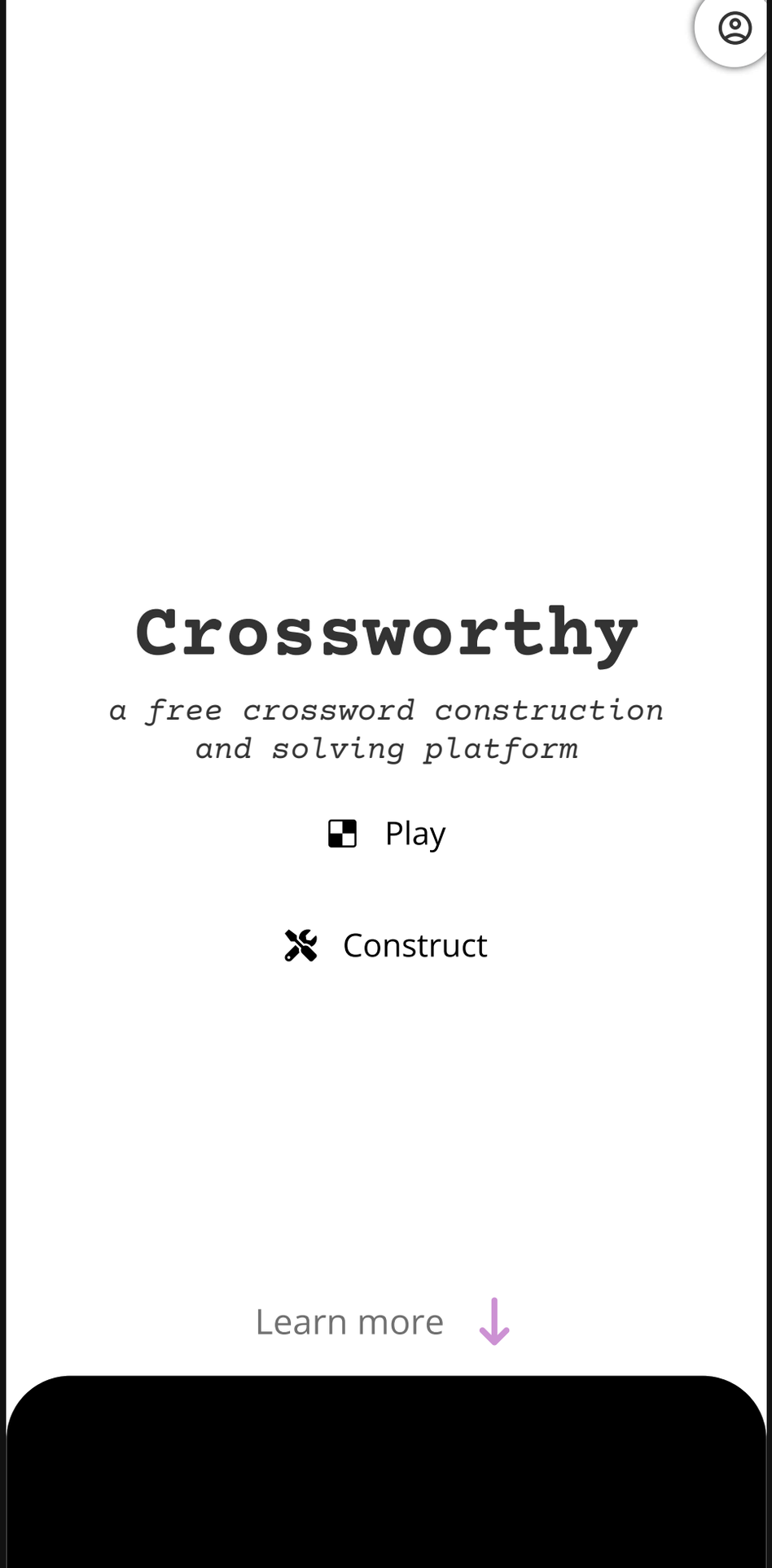
> Disclaimer: I have two crosswords published by the Los Angeles Times. I am not qualified to give advice on how to construct crosswords that may be accepted by other publications, e.g. the New York Times.

What we'll be making

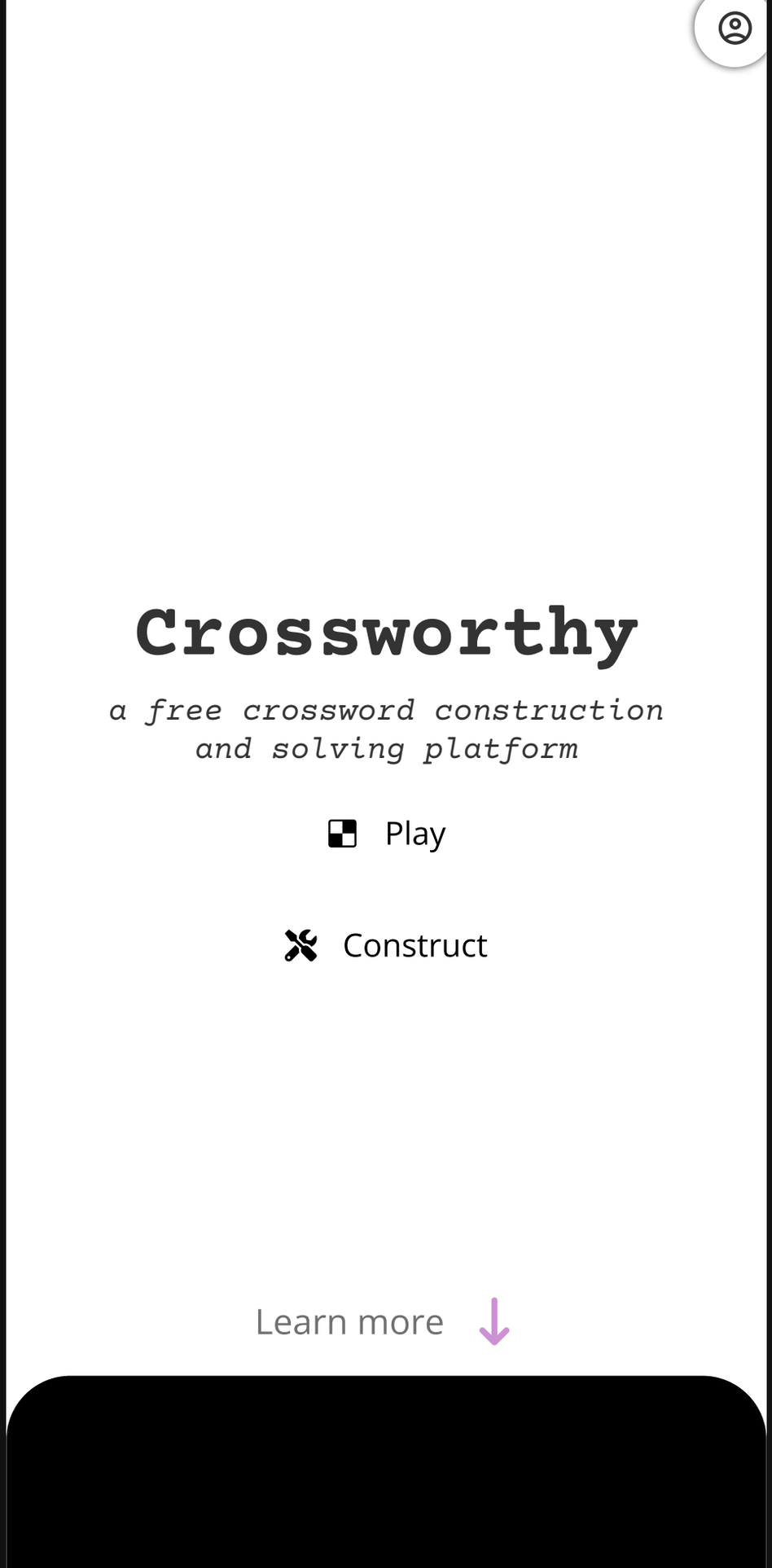
- We'll be constructing a Mini (5x5) crossword.
- The initial entries for this crossword will be the words HELLO and WORLD.
- We will follow a step-by-step process of the crossword construction process.

> For convenience, I will be using the web app Crossworthy for this demo. However, I recommend using a dedicated app on your personal computer. My personal app recommendation: Ingrid

> Certain slides will contain links to resources. The resources marked with ⭐s are the ones I consider the most valuable.



Let’s Get Started!



Step 0 – Learn

To construct crosswords, you need to know what goes into making a good one. To do this, choose all of the following:

1. Play a range of crosswords. Some crosswords will "feel good", and some will not. You will pick up the rules of crosswords this way.
   - ⭐ Daily Crossword Links
2. Read players' thoughts:
   - ⭐ Crossword Fiend
   - Rex Parker Does the NYT Crossword 🌶️
   - XWord Info (💲 after *n* articles)
3. Read up on resources for crossword constructors:
   - ⭐ Crossword Publication Specs
   - ⭐ Crossword Constructor's Handbook 💲
   - ⭐ OLLI Course: Constructing Crosswords
   - Wayward Grids (rejected crossword submissions with feedback)
4. Communities:
   - Crosscord

Crossworthy

a free crossword construction and solving platform

Play

Construct

Learn more ↓

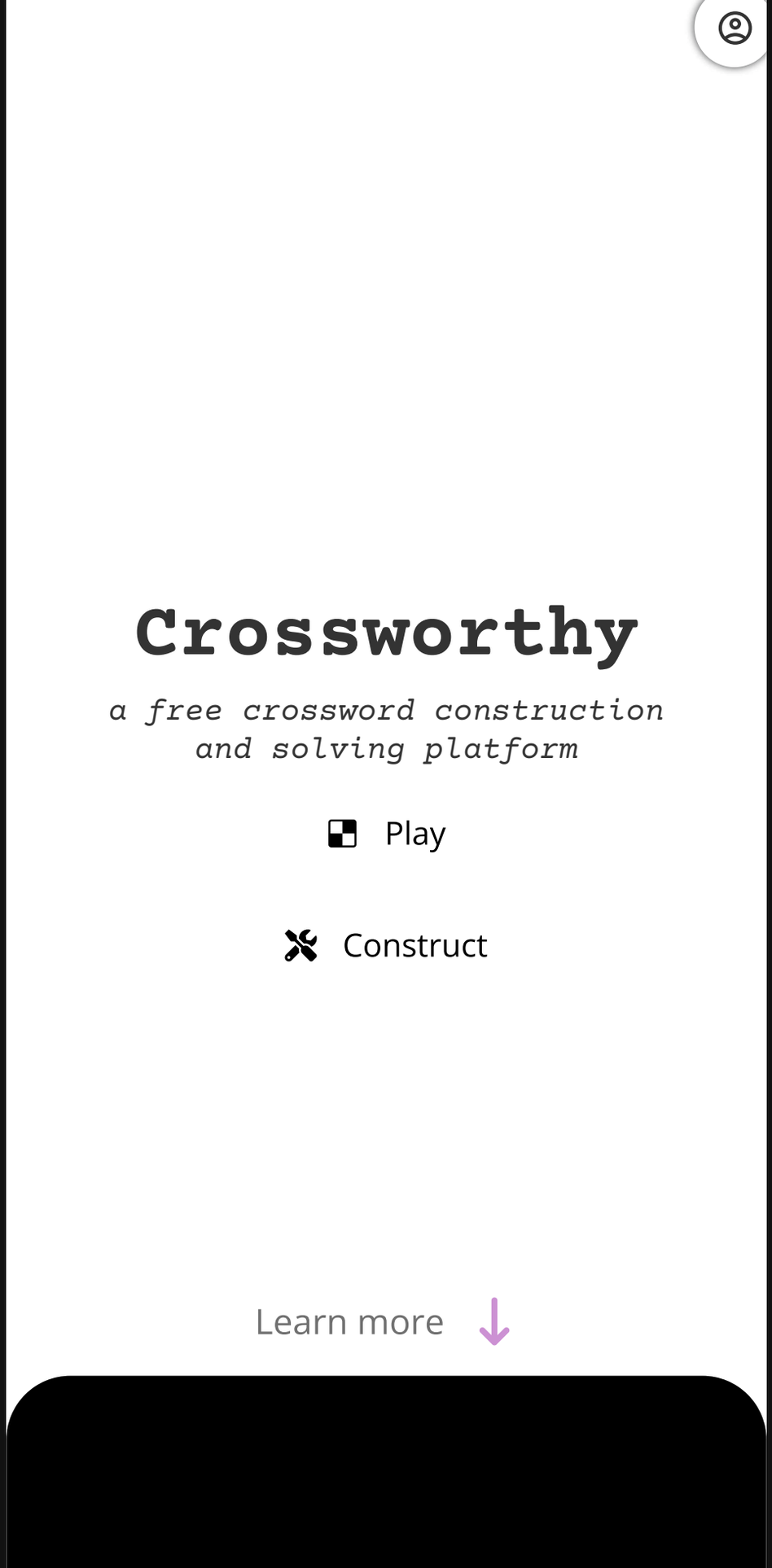
Step 1 – Get a Crossword Construction App

Choose one:

- Crosserville (web)
- Crossword Compiler $ (Windows-only)
- Crossworthy (web)
- ⭐ Ingrid

Alternative options:

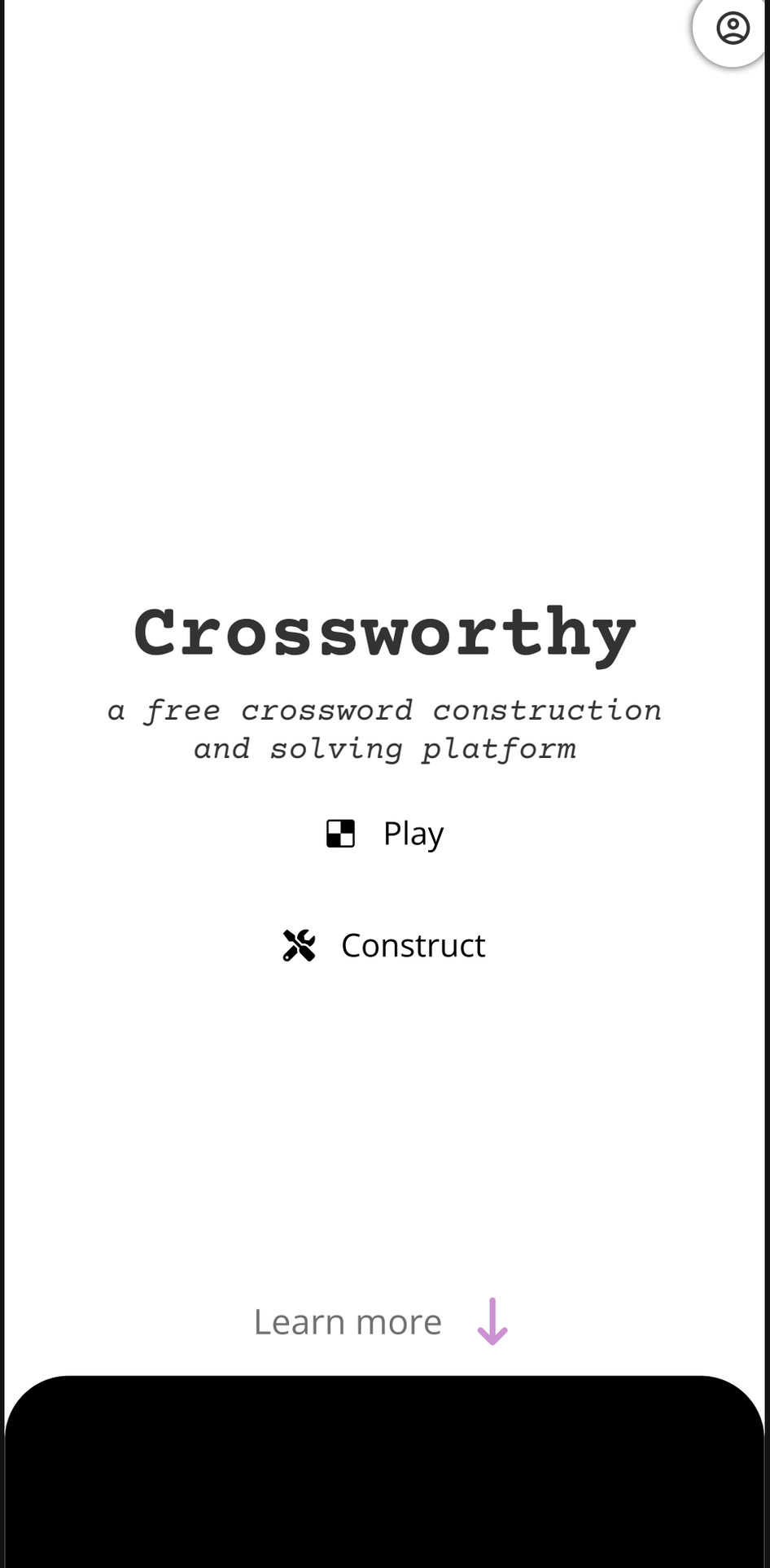
- CrossFire $
- Crosshare (web)



Step 2 – Get a Good Crossword Dictionary

- Crosswords use their own dictionaries, called "word lists".
- Word lists are typically text files with words associated with a certain score. I.e. more desirable words are given higher priority when finding a fillable grid.
- Higher-quality word lists produce more entertaining puzzles, so getting a good one helps your odds of getting an accepted submission.
- These word lists function as a **starting point**. You *need* to curate word scores instead of assuming the starting point is good enough.

> Note: I score my wordlist using a tagging system. This way, I can rescore all words under a certain tag at once. This is helpful as different types of crosswords prioritize different types of words.



Step 2 – Crossword Dictionaries

High-quality word lists:

- The Collaborative Word List
- Spread the Wordlist
- ⭐ XWord Info Word Lists $

Supplemental word lists:

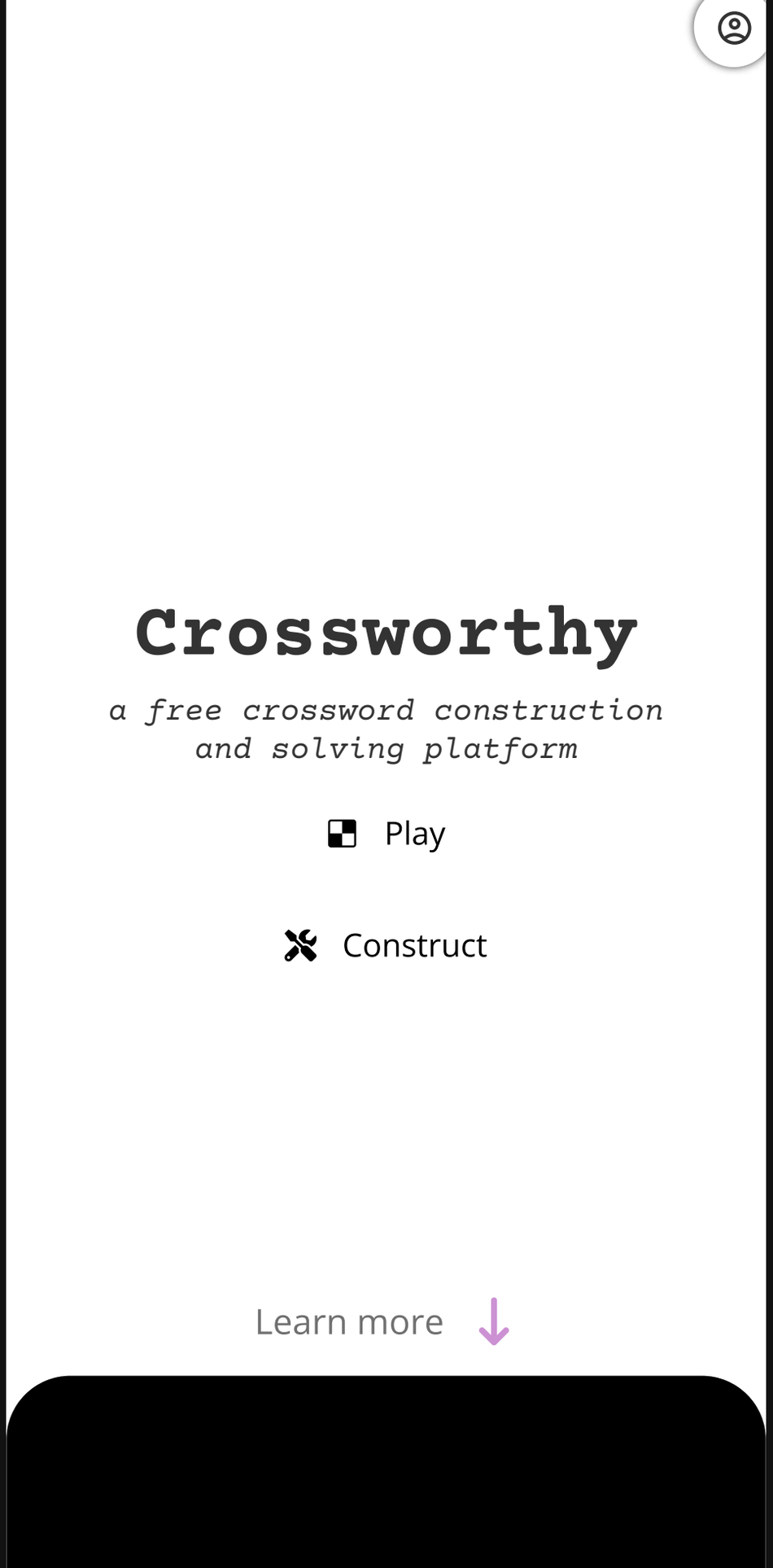
- John Kugelman's Wordlist
  - Modernizes the sensibilities used by the XWord Info Word List.

Other options:

- Matt Abate's Wordlist
- Peter Broda's Wordlist

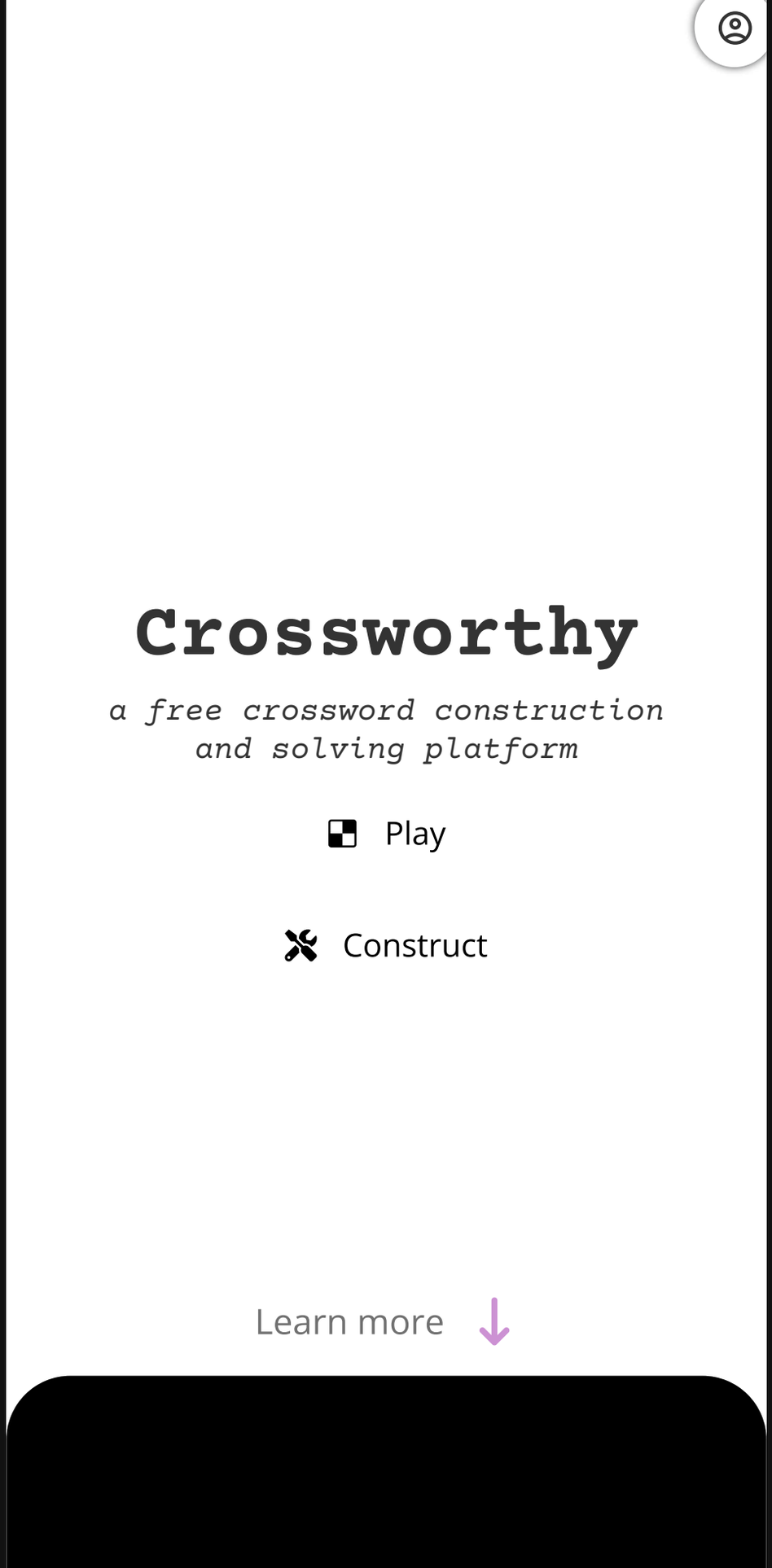
Also:

- Google Ngram Viewer
  - Look up words by popularity.
- ⭐ Onelook:
  - Search across dictionaries.
- Wikipedia Regex Search
  - Find terms not in dictionaries.
- ⭐ Wordlisted
  - Search through your wordlists.



Step 3 – Set Up Your App

1. Provide the crossword app with your wordlist.
2. Configure your grid accordingly.

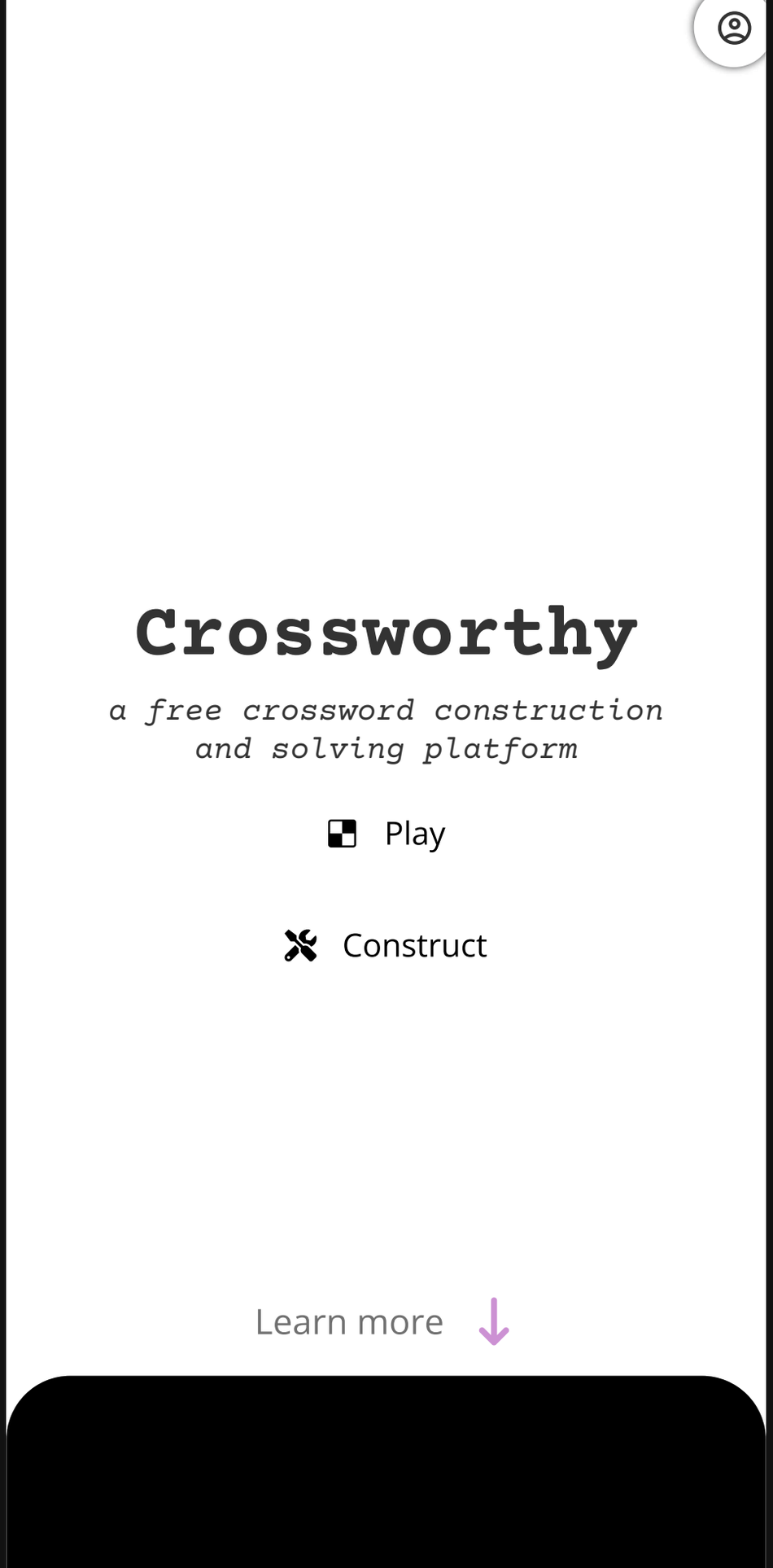


Step 4 – Fill Your Grid

1. Place your theme entries in the grid.
2. Add black squares (within reason) until your grid shows up as fillable.
3. Find "good entries" for each slot.

If you get stuck, try a different arrangement! Failing that, see if lowering the minimum word score helps.

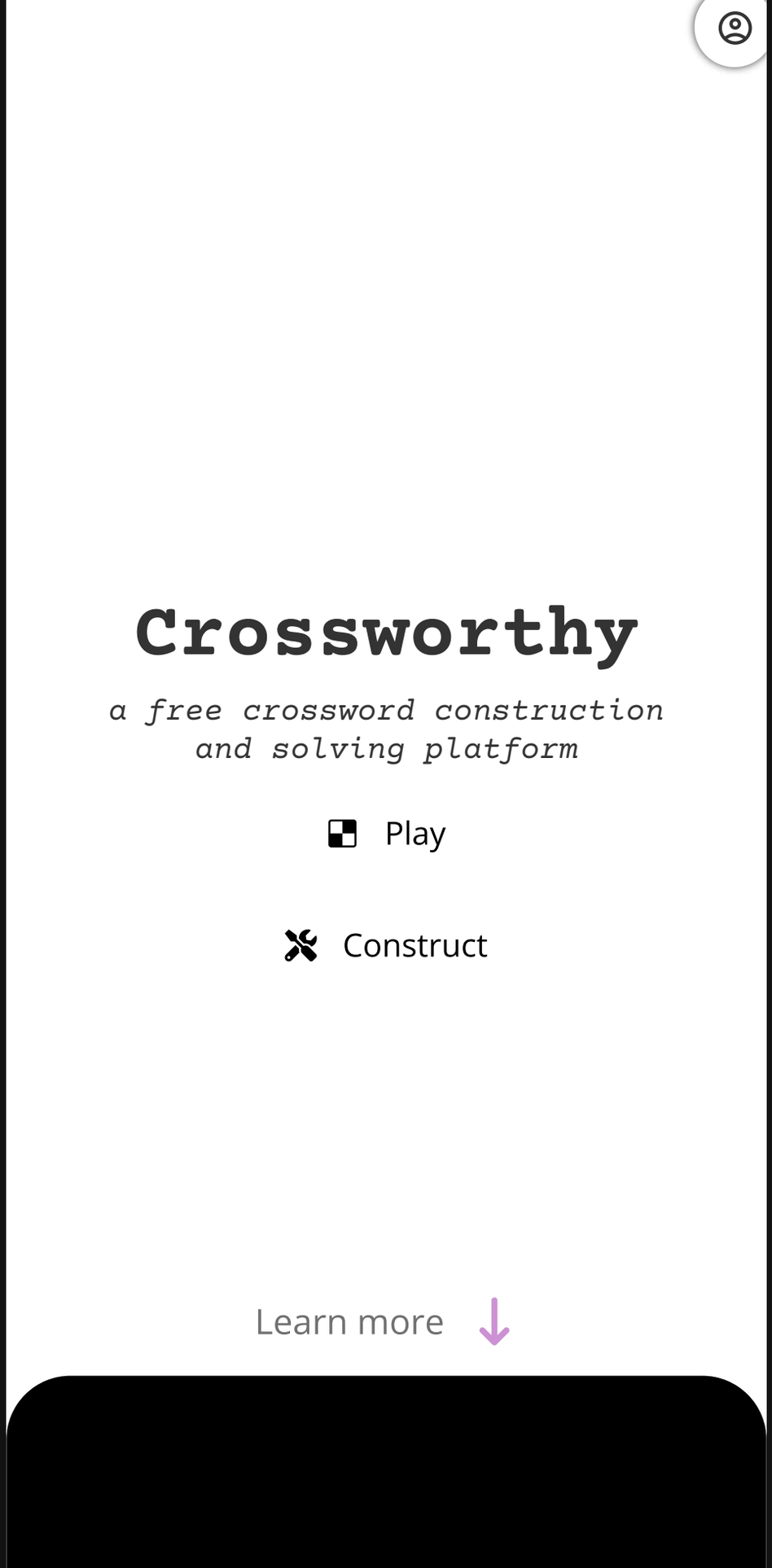
> Note: If you find yourself struggling to make a satisfying grid, consider checking out some of the resources for crossword resources linked to earlier. There is a book's worth of undescribed theory I'm glossing over here.



Step 5 – Review Your Grid

Make sure your grid is fun to solve for, e.g.:

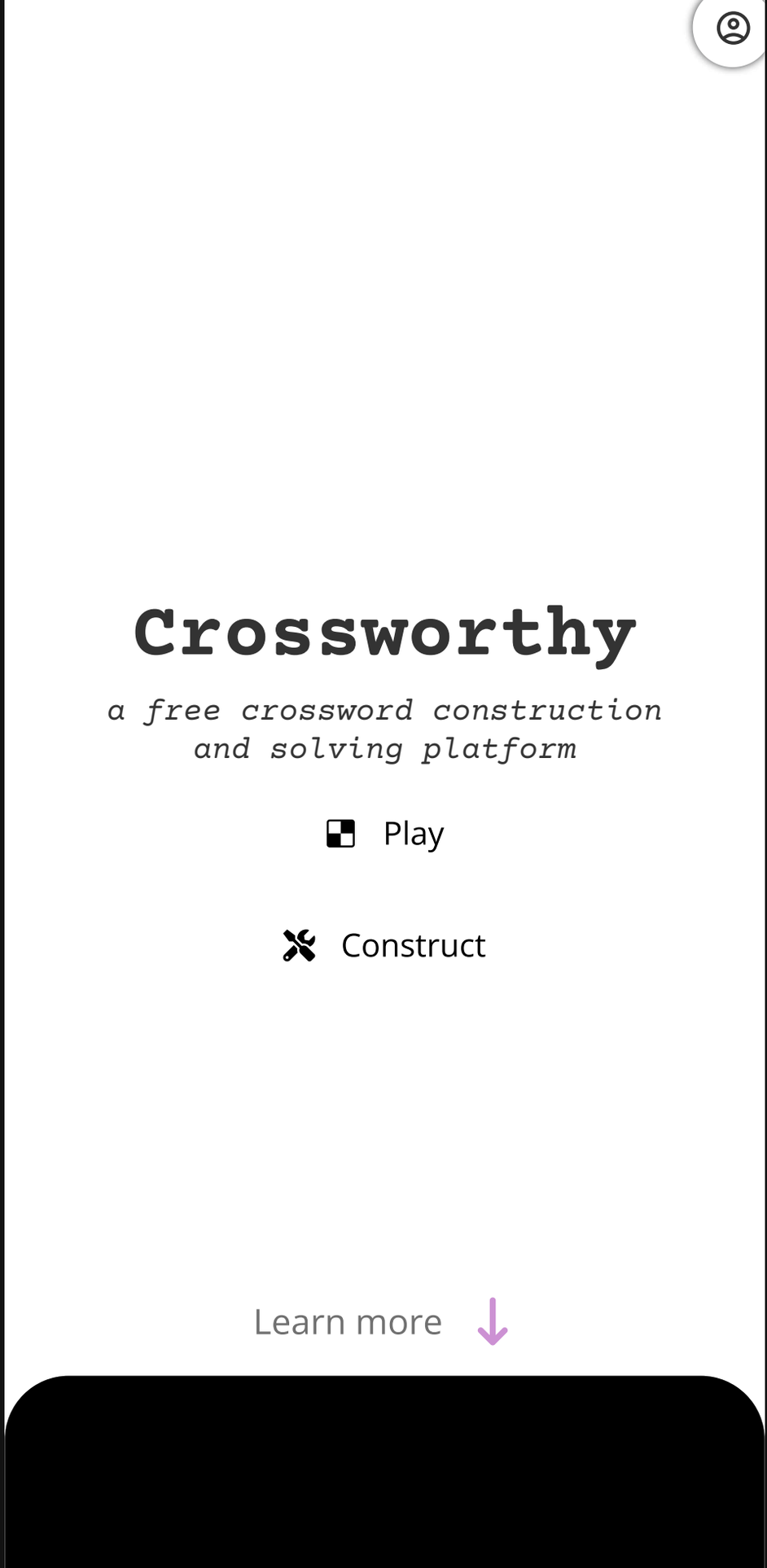
- A grid should not be unfinishable if they are stumped on a few select words, i.e. the grid should have multiple "paths" into certain areas of the grid.
- No two obscurities should intersect with each other.
- The player should not need specialized knowledge to solve one region of the grid (e.g. all sports clues or all movie clues).
- Don’t use two words that can only be clued as the "same puzzle" (e.g. EAT + ATE). Publishers often extend this to entries that share the same root (e.g. EAT UP and ATE IN).
- You have more fun options for entries the longer they are, so try to strike a balance with how many "short" entries your grid has. E.g. publishers often ask that the # of 3-letter words in a crossword be kept within reasons.



Step 6 – Write Clues

- Clues should be fun but fair, i.e. the part of speech of the clue should match the part of speech of the answer.
- Use a wide range of "clue types", i.e. don't rely purely on dictionary definitions. E.g. you can also:
  - Clue by example
  - Reference pop culture
  - Make a pun

> Note: Cluing determines how difficult your crossword is. You can crank up the difficulty of a crossword by relying on trickier clues.



Step 6 – Cluing Resources

Clue databases:

- ⭐ Crosserville Theme Search
- ⭐ Matt Ginsberg's Clue Database
- Saul Pwanson's Clue Database

Information databases:

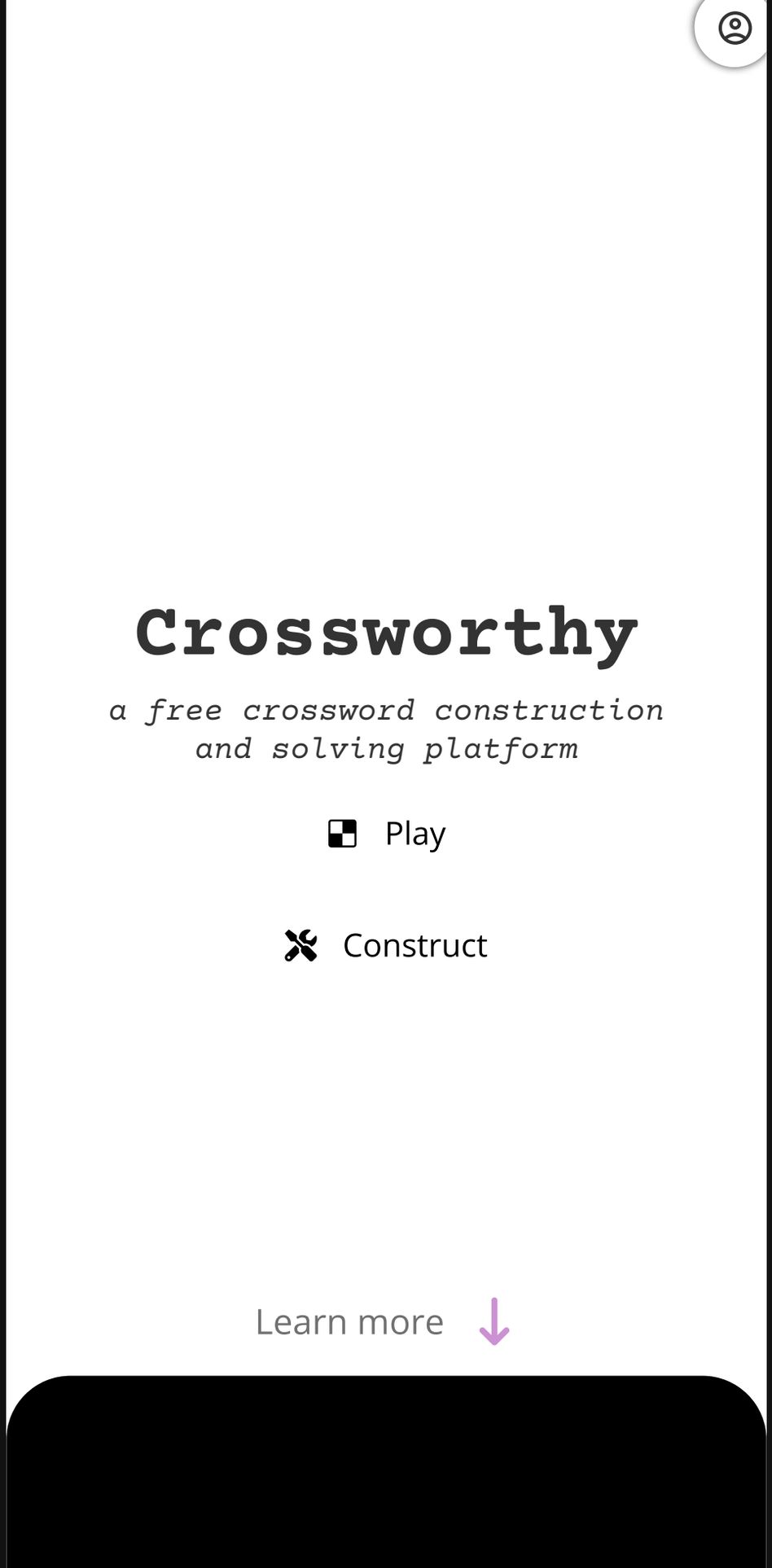
- TheFreeDictionary | Idioms
- ⭐ TV Tropes (for pop culture, but unreliable)
- ⭐ Wikipedia
- Wiktionary

Other options:

- ⭐ Google Gemini 3 Thinking (not sponsored)

Clue difficulty examples:

- CommuniCrossings
- New York Times

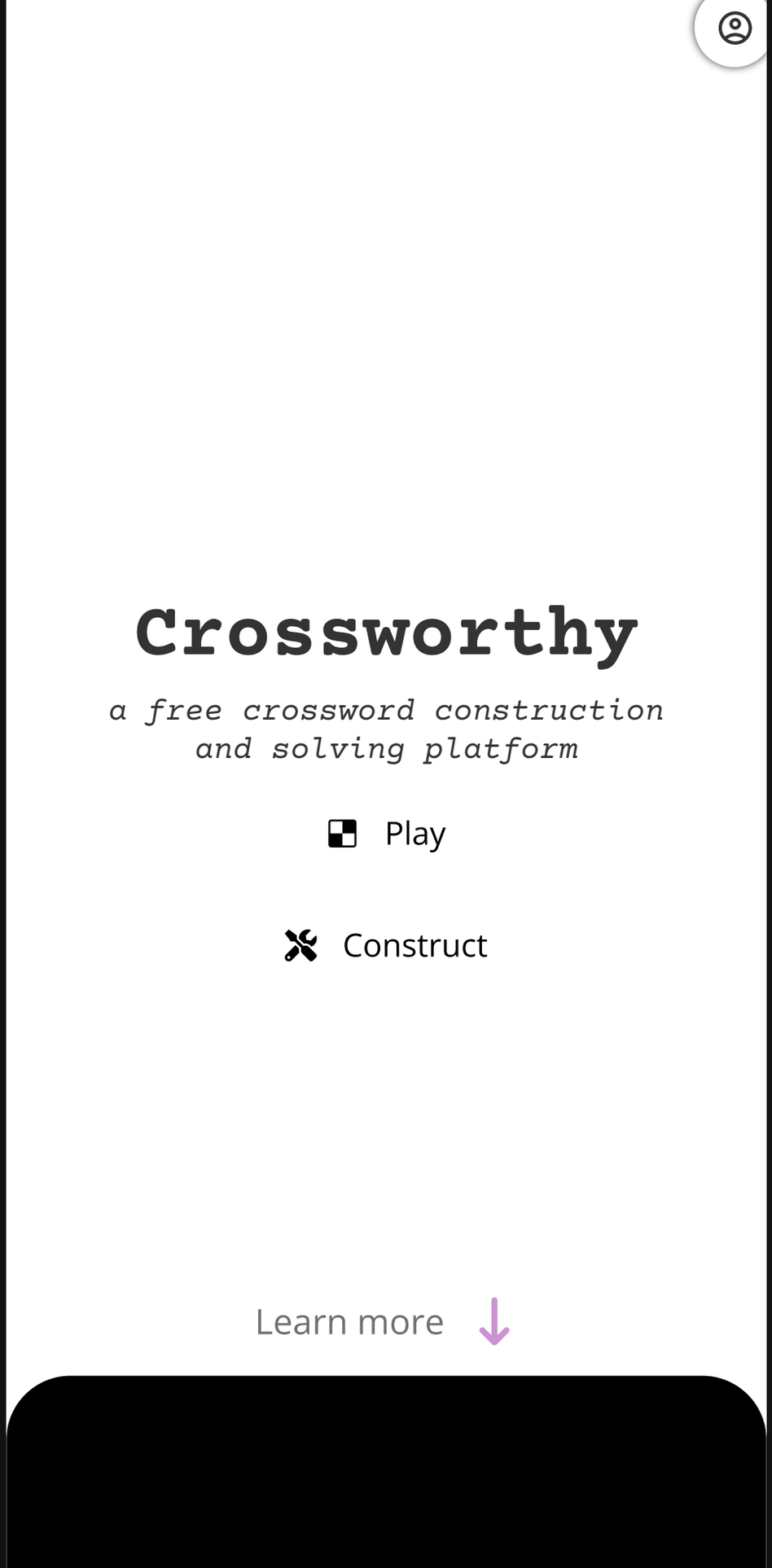


Step 7 – Share Your Crossword!

Not only do you get to enjoy the fruits of your labor, but you also get to see how your puzzle works in practice. Playtesting ensures the theme of your crossword is recognizable and whether players found any particular parts of the puzzle too straightforward or too tricky.

I like to open a group session in Crossworthy to look at what how players navigate the puzzle and which words they attempt to fill in.

> If you can get feedback earlier in the crossword construction process, that's helpful too!



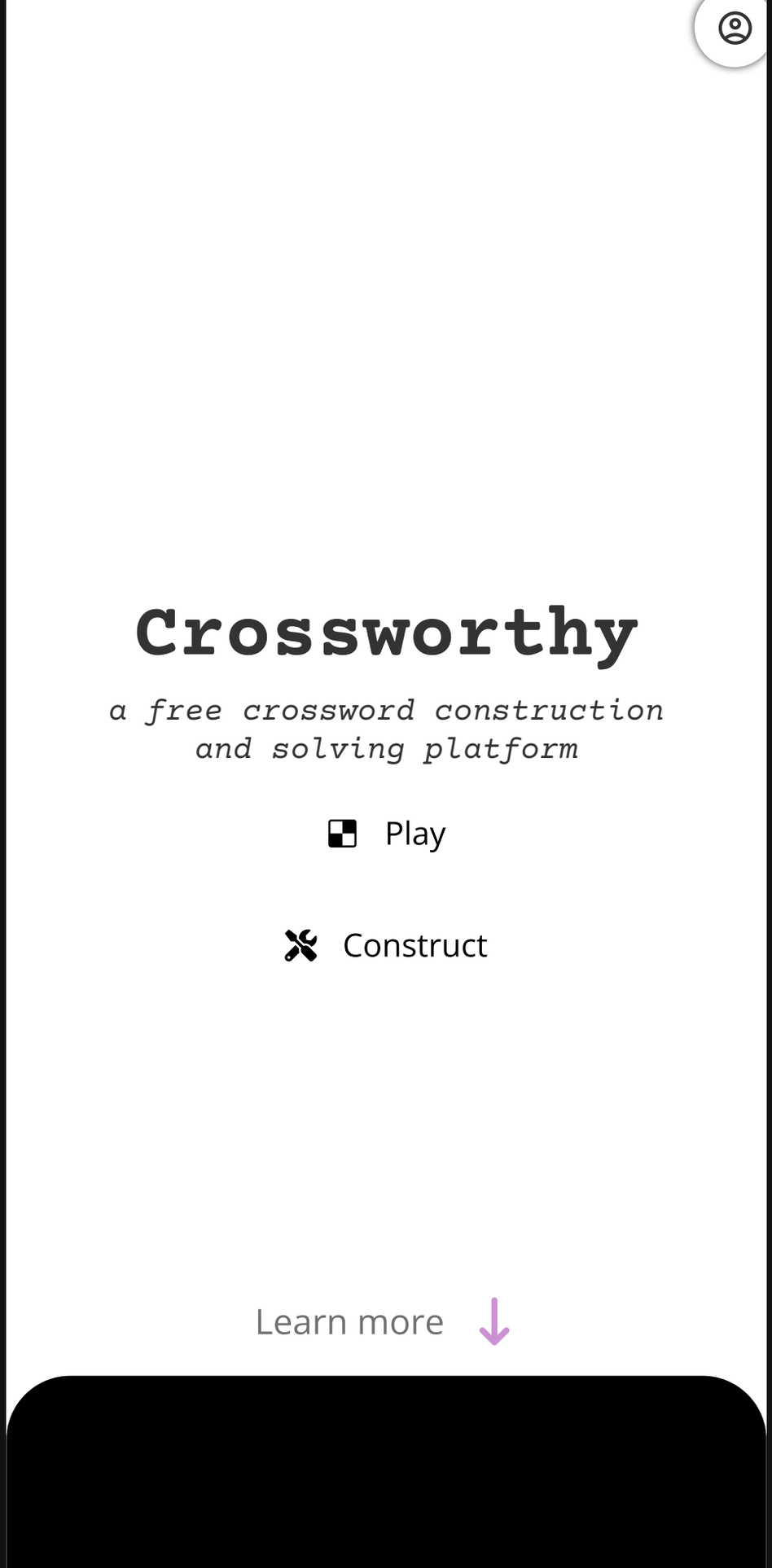
Step 7 – Share Your Crossword!

Sites to host your crossword:

- Crosshare 📊
- Cross with Friends 👥
- Crossword Nexus
- Crossworthy 👥
- squares.io 👥 📊

👥 has multiplayer

📊 has stats



That’s it!

Links to these slides will be available.

Any questions?

Crossworthy

a free crossword construction and solving platform

Play

Construct

Learn more